

Originally an oral tradition, magic entered the written Greek record in the 6th century BCE. This was when ideas of magic were filtering westward from the Persian empire (and magicians were sometimes called “Chaldeans,” from a Persian province bordering Babylonia). A large number of spells survive from the 4th century BCE, and there was another upsurge in the 1st century BCE, typified by the Greek Magical Papyri found in Egypt. These cover many topics, including spells for healing, evading evil, and harming enemies.

Binding magic

Behind much of the theory of Greek magic lay the concept of binding—taking control of the physical or intellectual attributes of the victim and binding them to the will of the spell caster. Even celestial

IN PRACTICE

Magical figurines

Magic rituals sometimes involved the use of clay or metal figurines, representing the person to be bound or cursed. The limbs were often symbolically tied or broken, or the body pierced with nails (ideally taken from a shipwreck). The figurine was then placed in a miniature lead coffin (see below), inscribed with the victim’s name and the curse, and buried in a place of magical power such as at a crossroads.



objects such as the moon could be bound, in a ritual known as “drawing down the moon,” a speciality of Thracian witches who collected “moon-foam” to act as an amplifier in magical potions.

Public and private curses

Curses were a specialized form of binding magic. They were sometimes public, such as those on tombs that warned passers-by against violating the grave, or civic, such as that associated with the vow made by the people of Thera to colonize Cyrene in North Africa. As the Therans made the vow, they melted wax figurines so that if they failed to fulfill their oath, a curse would strike and they, too, would melt.

More private curses were made secretly on papyri and deposited underground. They often began with the formula “I bind,” listing all the parts of the victim’s body, although for some targets, such as athletes, they might simply bind the limbs of an effigy to ruin the person’s ability to compete.

To bind the will of the gods was a far more difficult task, involving a branch of magic known as theurgy. Practitioners of theurgy might project themselves into the divine realm through dreams, or achieve visions through lecanomancy (the dropping of oil on water in a basin—the resulting ripples inspiring divine communication), or libanomancy (making contact with the gods by looking at the patterns of a flame from a lamp).

“And take 13 copper needles and stick one in the brain while saying ‘I am piercing your brain’ ...”

GREAT PARIS MAGICAL PAPYRUS, 3RD CENTURY CE

